



A firewall inspects each and every packet that arrives at your computer before it is seen by any other software running on your system. Similarly, it also inspects every packet being sent from your computer—before it is sent. It can “filter” arriving packets based upon any combination of the originating machine’s IP address and port and the destination machine’s IP address and port. As an example, if your computer is a Web server, remote computers can connect to your computer using the port 80, which is for http. The firewall will inspect every incoming packet and allow connections only via port 80 and deny connections on all other ports.

Thus, even if a Trojan horse gets installed on the computer and opens a listening port, the Trojan scanner at the other end will not be able to communicate with the Trojan horse since all the attempts to contact it will be blocked by the firewall.

Some Important Rules For Security

- ❑ Update Windows before installing new security software. Install the latest patches and service packs for your version of Windows, using Microsoft’s Windows Update Web site.
- ❑ To avoid conflict, do not use two firewalls at the same time. Before installing a new firewall, completely uninstall the first. The Windows firewall offers only basic protection, and it is recommended

that you install a third-party firewall—disable the Windows firewall before you do so, of course.

- ❑ After installing any security software, immediately check for updates at the vendor’s Web site.
- ❑ Do not install Windows and then get online to download anti-virus software or definitions. Before you get online even for the first time, you should have installed an anti-virus with updated definitions off a CD.
- ❑ Use an online testing service such as Microsoft’s Windows Live Safety Center at <http://safety.live.com/> or Kaspersky’s Free Online Virus Scanner at <http://www.kaspersky.com/virusscanner> if you can’t afford or procure anti-virus software. During an online virus scan, an ActiveX component is downloaded to your computer, which does the actual scanning. You need to stay online for the length of the scan.

What Are The Types Of Viruses?

Virus

A piece of code that is loaded onto your computer without your knowledge and that can run against your will. Most viruses can replicate themselves. All computer viruses are manmade. A simple virus that can make a copy of itself over and over again is relatively easy to produce, and even such a

simple virus is dangerous because it will quickly use all available memory and bring the system to a halt. More dangerous viruses are capable of transmitting themselves across networks and bypassing security systems.

Boot Sector Virus

A virus that infects the boot sector of a disk. An attempt to boot from a disk infected with a boot sector virus will cause the virus to become active in memory. Every time you boot your system from that point on, the virus will be active in memory. The boot sector is a sector at the beginning of a disk that identifies the disk’s architecture. For startup disks, bootable CDs and bootable hard disks, the boot sector also contains a program that loads the operating system.

Macro Virus

These are small programs written in the macro language of an application, which can normally only spread within files of that application.

In order to infect you, they need the corresponding applications to be activated and at least one of the infected macros should have been executed.

What Should I Do When A Virus Is Detected?

When a virus is found, you have the option to disinfect the file, and if this fails, you can delete the file. If the file refuses to delete, or if the infected file is important, you can opt to back it up safely to the “virus chest,” or “quarantine” it, so it can’t cause any further infection and also so that it may be repaired in the future when a solution becomes available for that particular infection. ■

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Why Are Virus Removal Tools Needed?

Virus removal tools are free executables designed to eliminate specific viruses. Using a virus removal tool does not require you to install any anti-virus software. Examples of free virus removal tools are the Stinger remover from McAfee at <http://vil.nai.com/vil/stinger>, a host of tools from Symantec at www.symantec.com/avcenter/tools.list.html and from BitDefender at www.bitdefender.com/site/Download/browseFreeRemovalTool.



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